ahead.

“What’s a *poinçonneur*?” Rose asked.

“Ticket punchers at the entrance of every platform.” He explained. “Have you never been on the Métro?”

Léa squeezed Rose’s hand, as if warning not to ask too many questions. But Rose couldn’t help it. Everything was new and different. Following him, they crossed the hall, footfalls and voices echoing off the glass overhead, hitting the stone walls with a cacophony like thunder. He guided them through the labyrinthine network of doors, passageways and stairs until he motioned to the one they would take to descend into the Métro.

Rose hesitated, unwilling to leave the train station—there was still so much she hadn’t seen—but Léa grabbed her hand again and yanked her along.

“You’re the one wanting to come to Germany, so keep up.” Léa’s voice was stern.

There were as many people mounting the stairs as going down and it was chaotic trying to make their way through the crowd. At one point, the guard stopped and grabbed a man who brushed Léa’s shoulder, seemingly by accident. He shouted at the man to return whatever he’d taken. Léa’s eyes went wide as the man reached into his pocket and pulled out Léa’s small silk coin purse with the brass clips, dropping it into Léa’s hand and dashing off up the stairs. Rose couldn’t believe it.

“Pickpockets,” their German escort warned. “Don’t let anyone bump you. Understand?”

“Yes,” Léa said, nodding. She pushed the coin purse into the front pocket of her dress.

They presented their tickets to the woman in the small metal cabinet at the bottom of the stairs, and she punched two holes in the middle of the yellow paper before returning them. The sisters moved down the tiled narrow platform. The wall, covered in white ceramic tiles, had a large enamel plate in the center that read *Gare d’Austerlitz*, and under it was a long wooden bench where people sat. A train drew into the station, and the passengers on the bench surged forward to the opening doors. Their escort pushed the sisters inside, following after. Then the doors closed, and the train was off.

“How many stops?” Rose asked, clinging to Léa’s arm as she tried to